

Building tomorrow's African financing rails.

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Africa Forward 2026 gathered in Nairobi the public, private and institutional actors of African financing. It was an opportunity to collectively initiate a reflection on new digital transaction technologies and how they can transform the financing of development initiatives across the continent.

The diagnosis is widely shared: **Africa remains structurally undercapitalized**. Annual financing needs to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals are estimated at between **\$1.3 and \$1.6 trillion**, while currently deployed flows cover less than 10% of that amount. Global capital exists – what is missing are the channels capable of efficiently directing it toward the continent.

Our conviction is that **new financial technologies offer a way forward** – not as an abstract promise, but as infrastructures already partially in place: the Stellar Foundation working with the Bank of Ghana on the Akuna Wallet, Mélanin Kapital with Ecobank, as well as Minah.io to mobilize diaspora savings, alongside the payment corridors operated through MoneyGram, Taptap Send, and Flutterwave.

These infrastructures make three transformative shifts possible: **attract more capital** by lowering entry thresholds and democratizing access to African assets; **improving traceability** through non-falsifiable impact measurement embedded directly into the financial contracts themselves;

and **mobilize the diaspora** which represents over 200 million people and more than \$100 billion in annual remittances.

At Africa Forward, President Emmanuel Macron announced a **€23 billion investment commitment** for the continent, including €14 billion from France and **€3.76 billion dedicated to digital technologies and artificial intelligence**. This sectoral envelope should not be read as a standalone investment silo. Digital embodies the cross-cutting infrastructure that conditions the performance of all other sectors.

“ This investment in digital and AI must be meta-sectoral.
The stake is to turn it into a lever capable of amplifying long-term investment capacity – particularly private capacity. ”

Julien Gakpe – CEO & Co-founder Minah

The signatories of this op-ed operate across different sectors – some in the public and institutional sphere, others in private finance and investment. Yet all arrive at the same conclusion: **Africa needs more capital, deployed under better conditions, with stronger standards of traceability and impact**. The digitalization of financial rails will be one of the key levers to achieve this.

It is in this spirit that we publish this joint op-ed, setting out concrete recommendations that we submit to Africa Forward participants and to the ecosystems on both sides of the Euro-African corridor.

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Recommendations to turn new transaction technologies into a lever of financial sovereignty

01 SEIZE THE STRUCTURAL LAG AS A LEAPFROG OPPORTUNITY.

The rails of the international financial system are shifting to distributed infrastructures at a pace that creates a clear risk for the continent: that today's financing gap could simply be reproduced on the next generation of financial infrastructure.

The €23 billion investment commitment announced in Nairobi by Emmanuel Macron reflects a strong ambition, and we call on the public and private stakeholders engaged at Africa Forward 2026 to allocate a portion of this capital to pilot projects serving as proof-of-concept for the financing infrastructures of tomorrow. Target: at least €50 million committed in the WAEMU zone within a fully digitalized framework based on shared ledgers by the end of 2027.

02 TURN THE DIASPORA INTO A PROFESSIONAL INVESTMENT CHANNEL, BACKED BY NEW TECHNOLOGIES.

Support the deployment of structured diaspora investment products – including dedicated savings accounts, diaspora bonds, and productive investment vehicles – by leveraging established financial actors alongside new financial infrastructures that reduce entry barriers, facilitate cross-border flows, and make impact more transparent and measurable.

Target: double the share of remittances that become productive investments.

03 STANDARDIZE AND DIGITALIZE AFRICAN IMPACT INDICATORS.

Co-build an open standard for digitalized development indicators, designed alongside United Nations Development Programme, continental regulators, and organizations such as Blockchain for Good, in order to launch an initial operational framework. The immediate challenge is not blockchain itself, but digitalization: translating indicators into interoperable parameters – audit trails, JSON schemas, certified oracles, and similar tools – that can be directly embedded into programmable financial contracts. Only under these conditions can impact measurement move beyond a declarative exercise and become a verifiable, shared, and enforceable proof.

04 ALIGN EUROPEAN AND AFRICAN IMPACT CRITERIA.

Engage joint work between authorities and ecosystems on both sides of the corridor to align ESG and SDG impact frameworks, prioritizing SFDR article 9 requirements to reach a matrix validated by the AMF. The objective is for this matrix to serve as a reference in discussions with other competent European authorities. Under this condition, investment from the diaspora and European impact investors will become more fluid, and the risk of structural greenwashing – which today weighs on the credibility of sustainable products with African exposure – can effectively be removed.

05 BRIDGE MICA AND AFRICAN REGULATORY SANDBOXES.

Engage joint work between European regulators (AMF, ESMA) and African ones (BCEAO, Nigeria SEC, Mauritius) to ease the reading, by private actors, of cross-border operating conditions. The goal is to allow African tokenized issuances to access European investors without regulatory friction.

06 CREATE A PAN-AFRICAN THINK TANK ON IMPACT AND DIGITAL ASSETS.

Launch a dedicated working circle on impact and digital assets, directly involving the actors that make the market: African fintechs, continental pension funds, diaspora neobanks, and emerging asset managers. Target: bring out operational, immediately actionable recommendations and designate the actors ready to carry them forward over the next eighteen months.

07 ANCHOR THIS WORK IN THE AGENDA OF THE ABIDJAN CONSENSUS AND NAFAD.

Plug into the cycle of periodic reviews convened by the African Development Bank following the Abidjan Consensus, making new financing technologies and diaspora mobilization an explicit pillar of the New African Financial Architecture for Development, on a 2030 horizon.

NEXT STEPS

This op-ed is an opening **for reflection and initiatives**.

We call on public, private and institutional actors to take it up, complete it, challenge it and extend it.

Africa Forward 2026 has the potential to become a defining moment in the emergence of initiatives through which these channels evolve from a simple promise into a shared infrastructure capable of addressing the challenges of tomorrow's Africa.

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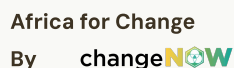
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I commit for Africa



M Studio / Ring Africa



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